

VALLEY OAK CUSTOMS

Design Manager

Quick Start Guide

Version 1.6.0

October 2026

Find it. Organize it. Open it. Make it.

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1 What Design Manager is

Design Manager is a Windows organizer and visual browser for CNC files. It catalogs files where they already live and stores organization separately.

- Browse SVG and DXF designs plus related SheetCam JOB, image, TAP, and NC files.
- Search, preview, favorite, tag, collect, and record shop notes.
- Normal organization and migration do not move or change CNC source files. A file changes only when you explicitly confirm a supported file operation.

File safety: Design Manager never executes TAP or NC machine programs.

2 Install upgrade and activate

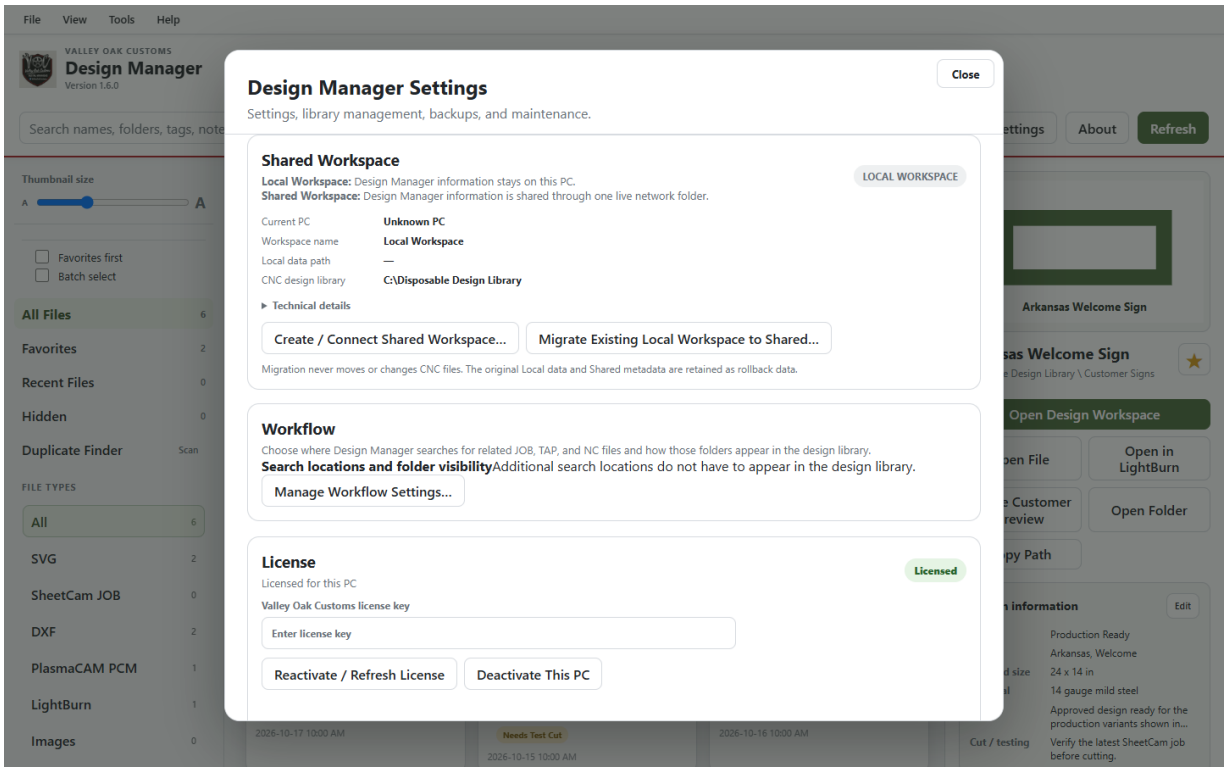
Windows 10 or 11 (64-bit) is required. The installer includes .NET 8; Microsoft Edge WebView2 Runtime remains an external Windows prerequisite.

- For an existing public installation, close Design Manager and run the v1.6.0 installer. Before replacing application files, Setup creates and verifies a timestamped backup under Documents\Valley Oak Design Manager\Pre-Upgrade Backups.
- If the required backup cannot be completed and verified, Setup stops before replacing application files. Setup does not automatically restore or roll back a database.
- Use Settings > License to activate. A purchase is a $99 perpetual Design Manager 1.x license for up to two PCs. New installations include a 30-day full-feature trial; Viewer Mode keeps safe access after the trial or when a license problem occurs.

3 Set Design Library Folders

Open Settings > Design Library Folders, add each top folder containing designs, choose whether to include subfolders, then Refresh.

- Folders remain in their original Windows locations. Removing one from the catalog does not delete it.
- In Local mode, folder exclusions omit selected subfolders from normal scans while preserving files and saved organization.

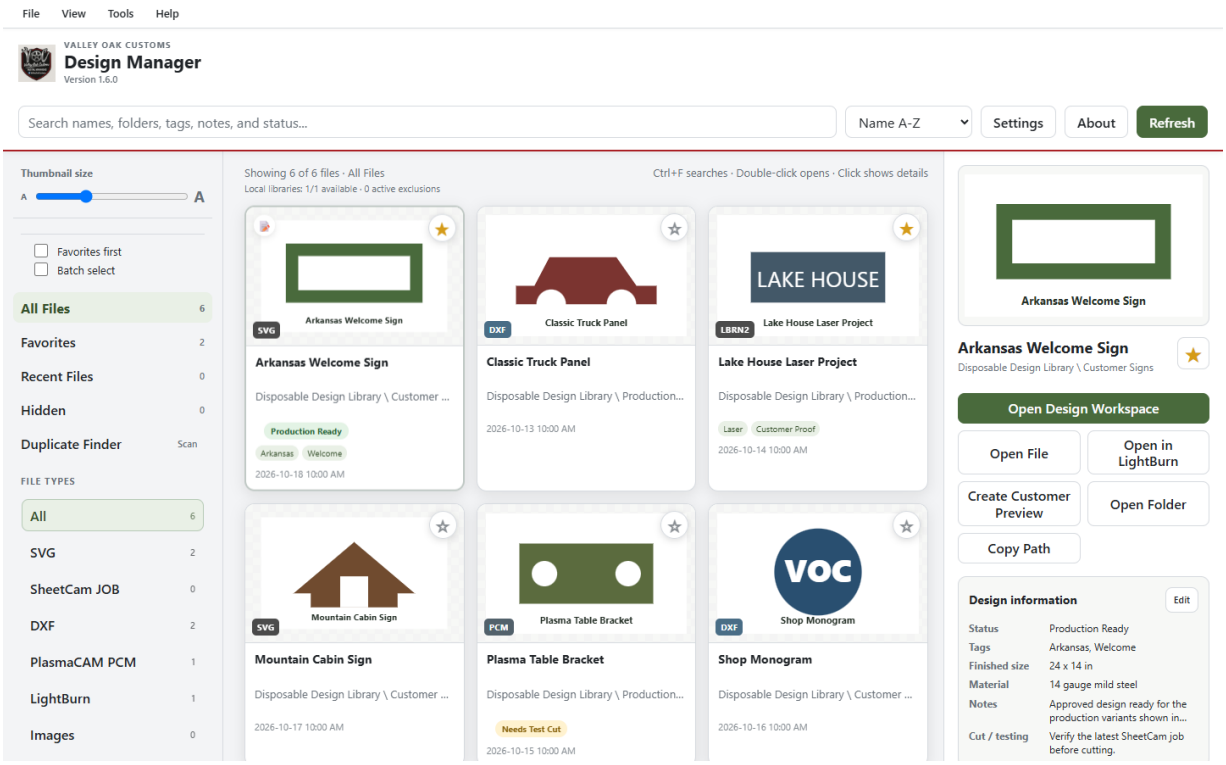


License, appearance, and Design Library Folder controls in Settings.

4 Understand the main screen

Filters are on the left, design cards are in the center, and details and quick actions are on the right. Each column scrolls independently while the application menu and search/sort toolbar remain available.

- Search filenames, folders, tags, notes, and status.
- Select once for details; double-click to open.
- Library cards include SVG, DXF, SheetCam JOB, PlasmaCAM PCM 1.01, LightBurn LBRN2, PNG, JPG/JPEG, and WebP. TAP and NC appear in related-file workflow views and safe previews.
- For an SVG or DXF, choose Open Design Workspace to keep the design and its manufacturing files together.



The v1.6 library: filters, design cards, and Details panel.

5 Find and organize a design

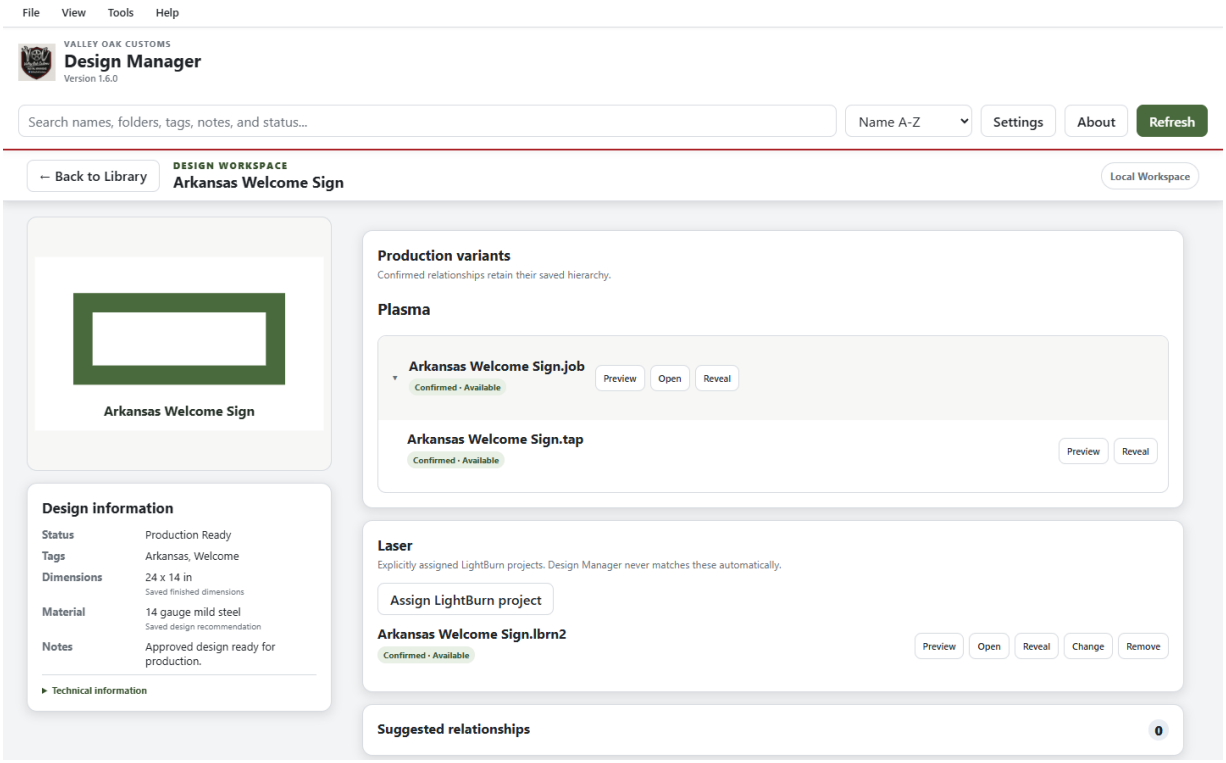
Select a file, then add a favorite, status, tags, collection, or notes. Wait for Saved automatically before closing.

- Use practical tags such as product type, theme, customer, season, or production readiness.

6 Use Design Workspace

Select an SVG or DXF and choose Open Design Workspace to see the design, shop information, and production variants in one view.

- Plasma keeps confirmed Design to JOB to TAP/NC hierarchy. Direct Design to TAP/NC links appear separately.
- Laser lists LightBurn projects that you explicitly assign. Design Manager never confirms a LightBurn project relationship from its filename.
- Suggested Plasma relationships remain clearly marked for review. Preview and Reveal use the existing safe file actions; a preview never runs machine code.
- Back to Library returns to the independently scrolling library layout.

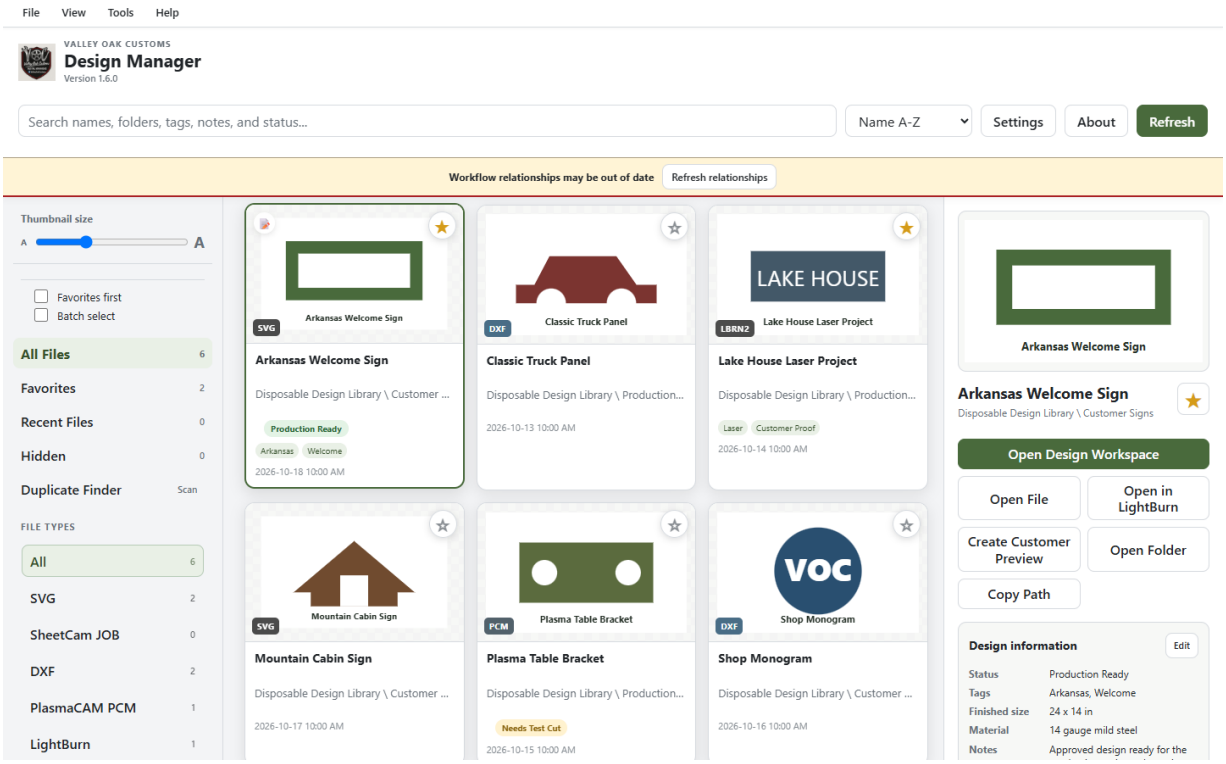


Design Workspace keeps confirmed Plasma and explicit LightBurn variants together.

7 Review and refresh related files

Needs Review and All Workflow Files start with the selected design and its confirmed manufacturing context. Choose Show all when you need the global list.

- Confirm good matches. Use Not related when files do not belong together. Saved Relationships retains earlier decisions so they can be reviewed or corrected.
- Library Refresh updates the file library. It does not silently confirm or rescan relationships. When the reminder appears, choose Refresh relationships to run the explicit related-file check.
- File Activity records actions in Design Manager and file changes it noticed; it does not prove that a part was manufactured.
- Mixed-sheet JOBs can link to several Designs. TAP and NC previews are visual inspection only; verify programs in your normal CAM and machine workflow.



Library Refresh and relationship refresh remain separate actions.

8 Use Local or Shared Workspace

Local organization stays on one PC. Shared Workspace gives registered shop PCs common metadata and Workflow relationships.

- The Administrator manages authoritative roots, upgrades, backups, device roles, and Shared settings. Members perform ordinary Shared work.
- A Shared Workspace can define multiple ordered library roots. Map each root on every PC to the path that reaches the same files.
- A designated Recovery Device can restore Administrator control if the Administrator PC is lost.

9 Use PCM and LightBurn files

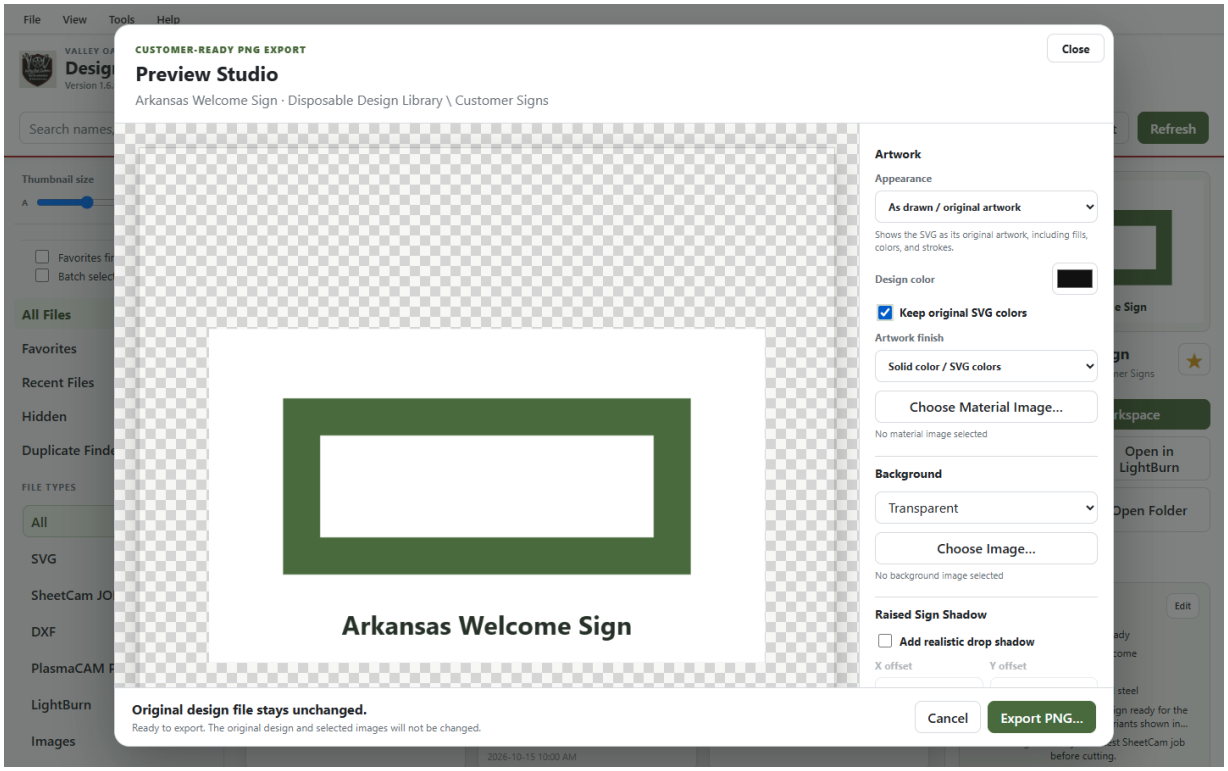
Version 1.6 adds read-only previews for supported PlasmaCAM PCM 1.01 files and LightBurn LBRN2 projects.

- PCM preview draws neutral line geometry from validated PCM 1.01 records. It does not edit, repair, convert, or validate the file for cutting. Unsupported or malformed PCM files safely show no generated preview.
- LBRN2 preview uses the PNG thumbnail embedded by LightBurn. If a project has no usable embedded thumbnail, Design Manager shows the normal no-preview fallback; it does not render native LightBurn vectors.
- Configure and test LightBurn in Settings, then use Open in LightBurn for SVG and DXF only. LBRN2 projects open through their normal Windows file association. Design Manager never changes the source file.

10 Create a customer proof

Select an SVG or DXF, choose Create Customer Preview, then export a separate PNG.

- The original SVG or DXF remains unchanged.



Preview Studio creates a separate PNG proof without changing the source design.

11 Backups recovery and updates

Open Settings for maintenance and recovery tools.

- The installer pre-upgrade backup protects the production profile, local integration state, and configured external Local Workspace data. It preserves Shared connection settings but never copies Shared Workspace network data.
- Local Back Up / Export protects settings and organization. Shared mode provides metadata-only Shared backup and isolated restore tools. CNC source folders still need their own independent backup.
- Keep the previous installer and all backup folders until v1.6 is accepted. Recovery is manual; follow the RECOVERY document installed with Design Manager.
- Choose Settings > Check for Updates manually. The update endpoint is contacted only when you request the check.

12 Quick troubleshooting

Start with Library Refresh, clear Search and filters, then verify the drive or network share in Windows.

- If related files changed, use Refresh relationships separately.
- Shared offline: restore access, then Refresh. Edits remain read-only while the workspace is unavailable.
- Missing relationship: inspect Needs Review, All Workflow Files, and Saved Relationships.
- For support, record the exact message and version from Help > About. Keep separate backups of CNC folders; Design Manager backups do not copy source designs.